in classical China and early India, where the aim was to explicate what were believed to be self-evident truths.[10] The contrast can be made even clearer in other ways: in literary representations before *c*. 450 BCE, kings, nobles, and leaders in the Graeco-Roman world aimed to shape actions through words. So, for instance, in the *Iliad*, Nestor's 'argument sweeter than honey' is what convinces Patroclus to fight Hector, and later histories support this and other similar images of the power of rhetoric.[11] To break the rhetorical spell cast by a one-way address, most of the Socratic dialogues recorded by Plato introduce an interruptive dialectical method which makes speakers stop, repeat themselves, and explain what they mean. For such thinkers, written material—which by its very nature is a closed and one-way discourse—was the antithesis of 'the give-and-take' that formed the basis of public discourse and dialogue.[12]

In ancient China speech was the primary medium for the exchange of ideas, and effective speech was thought a valid and vital instrument of government.[13] In fact, an early work called the *Book of History* (which took proper form in the sixth century BCE) was primarily concerned with speech and speech-making. Unlike Greece, however, the focus in China was not on individual excellence but on the authority of a venerated past.[14] The kind of person who found favour with the Chinese was not one who spoke to attract attention to himself by being different but who manifested through his personality the sagacity to conform to the social norm. Even in the philosophy of Confucius (*c*. 530–479 BCE), with its focus on the self-purification of individuals, the aim was to create a society in which harmony would prevail 'because propriety and loyalty would be practised by the rulers and the people.'[15]

As in China, the oral tradition in India is massive and long, people in both these old cultures showing much greater faith in speech than written communication.[16] The cultural ethos within which debate and discussion took place was rarely individualcentred. Debates were usually communal